miners and physicists. The Manhattan Project directly employed about 130,000 people, with millions more working to sustain them.[23] Robert Oppenheimer could devote himself to his equations because he relied on thousands of miners to extract uranium at the Eldorado mine in northern Canada and the Shinkolobwe mine in the Belgian Congo[24] – not to mention the farmers who grew potatoes for his lunch. If you want to make an atom bomb, you must find a way to make millions of people cooperate.

It is the same with all ambitious projects that humans undertake. A Stone Age band going to hunt a mammoth obviously needed to know some facts about mammoths. If they believed they could kill a mammoth by casting spells, their hunting expedition would have failed. But knowing facts about mammoths wasn't enough. The hunters also needed to risk death and show great courage. If they believed that a certain spell guaranteed a good afterlife for dead hunters, their hunting expeditions had a much higher chance of success. Even if the spell did not benefit dead hunters in any way, by fortifying the courage and solidarity of living hunters, it made a crucial contribution to the hunt's success.[25]

If you build a bomb and ignore the facts of physics, the bomb will not explode. But if you build an ideology and ignore the facts, the ideology may still prove explosive. While power depends on both truth and order, it is usually the people who know how to build ideologies and maintain order who give instructions to the people who merely know how to build bombs or hunt mammoths. Robert Oppenheimer obeyed Franklin Delano Roosevelt rather than the other way around. Similarly, Werner Heisenberg obeyed Adolf Hitler, Igor Kurchatov deferred to Joseph Stalin, and in contemporary Iran experts in nuclear physics follow the orders of experts in Shiite theology.

What the people at the top know, which nuclear physicists don't always realise, is that telling the truth about the universe is hardly the most efficient way to produce order among large numbers of humans. It is true that $E = mc^2$, and it explains a lot of what happens in the universe, but knowing that $E = mc^2$ usually doesn't resolve political disagreements or inspire people to make sacrifices for a common cause. Instead, what holds human networks together tends to be fictional stories, especially stories about intersubjective things like gods, money and nations. When it comes to uniting people, fiction enjoys two inherent advantages over the truth. First, fiction can be made as simple as we like, whereas the truth tends to be complicated,